



Cabs of the future

James Brighton drove the World's first RC cabs, a classic old English Taxi

Down with the 3DS

Nintendo dropped the price of the 3DS from ₹12,400 to ₹8,436



ASUS P8Z68-V Pro

operation, temperatures and voltages among other things.

ASRock Z68 Extreme7 Gen3 is the only Gen3 board we received which indicates support for future Ivy Bridge processors, although you can get a present generation board to support Ivy Bridge with a BIOS update. What you won't get however, is PCIe 3.0 chips, which will be the standard for future graphics cards. Gigabyte G1 Sniper2 is the only other board having PCIe 3.0 support. As of now you don't have any card which can exploit PCIe 3.0 speeds, but makes sense if you want to future-proof your system.

It's packed to the gills with features. The 10 SATA ports on the board will ensure you never run out of space to add more drives to your rig. There are also enough PCIe slots and an NVIDIA NF200 chip for you to run a three-way SLI setup. If you're using a single graphics card, you need to lodge it in the second PCIe slot from the CPU to get an x16 speed. Build quality is brilliant with sturdy heatsinks on the VRMs as well as the southbridge, it is one great looking board.

Winners: ASUS P8Z68-V Pro won the Best Buy as it offers most of the features, seen on the higher end P8Z68 Deluxe, at a very attractive price. ASRock Z68 Extreme7 Gen3 was awarded the Editor's Pick for

its plethora of features (which are equivalent to the ₹20,000 and up category of boards) and connectivity options. Another board which we found interesting even though it's not a winner, is the Gigabyte Z68XP-UD3-iSSD, specially for those who want to exploit the Intel RST feature.

₹10,000 to ₹14,000

This category has an assortment of boards that are quite distinct from each other. You get three form factors here: ATX, Micro ATX and Mini ITX.

Let's start off with the least attractive of the boards, the Intel DZ68DB. We call it the least interesting because it can't hold a candle to the aesthetics, build quality and feature set of the competing boards. There's a lot of free PCB space on the lower side making us wonder if it really had to be an ATX form factor board. Plus, it has a mixture of electrolytic and solid state caps while its competitors feature all-solid state caps. Pricing for such a basic board being ₹10,000 just does not make any sense.

ZOTAC Z68ITX A-E is the only mini ITX board in this category and a very interesting one at that. Lodge a high-end CPU in it, and the board functions like any other board. It has a decent feature set such as an on-board Wi-Fi adapter, POST

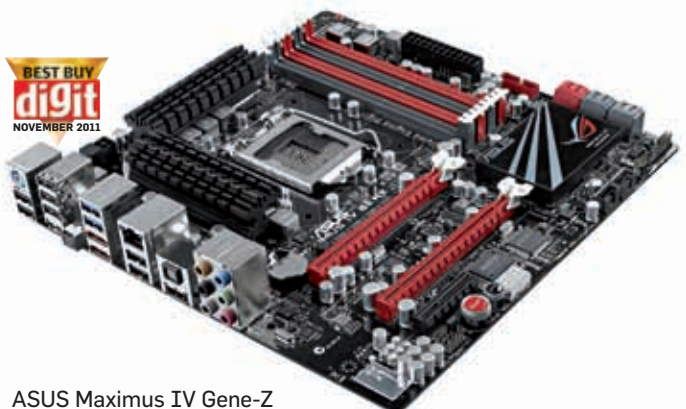
debug LED and a full PCIe x16 slot. The back panel IO is flush with connectivity options and makes for a perfect HTPC board. It has dual LAN port, dual HDMI ports and 8-channel audio out. The only unappealing part is the upward pointing SATA ports. With a heatsink and all other components, the board will be densely populated, in this case upward pointing SATA ports are just not ideal for efficient wire management. The ZOTAC bundles two Wi-Fi antennas, a USB 3.0 bracket, an 8-pin power connector to ease the connection to the on-board power connector and a mini DP-DP adapter. Don't expect much in terms of overclocking as there are limited options as compared to higher end boards. The Mini PCIe adapter can also function as an mSATA port in case you want to add an on-board SSD for RST in the future.

ASUS P8Z68-V and P8Z68-V LE belong to the same line of boards, but LE is a slightly stripped down version of the higher end V, which itself is slightly low on the specs when compared with V Pro and Deluxe. The P8Z68-V has an extra PCIe slot, much better heat-sinks over the VRMs, an extra PCI slot and an eSATA port over the P8Z68-V LE. The extra PCIe slot is ideal for gamers who want dual GPU gaming as it allows an x8/x8 con-

figuration as opposed to x16/x4 on the P8Z68-V LE.

The other ASUS board in this segment is the RoG Maximus IV Gene Z. It comes in the micro ATX form factor and to have a RoG feature set in this form factor is quite impressive. It lacks features such as RoG iDirect, RC Bluetooth, PCIe switches and USB BIOS Flashback, but for the price point, it's packed with quite a lot of features such as RoG Connect, ProBelt and SupremeFX X-Fi2 audio solution among others. There's a POST debug LED and an HDMI out. Build quality is similar to the higher end RoG board with sturdy heatsinks. Gamers can game with a single x16 or a dual x8/x8 configuration. We would have liked to see more USB 3.0 ports on the back panel though. Overclocking options are easily accessible thanks to the well designed ASUS UEFI BIOS. So in a way, those who can't afford the higher end Extreme Z (which is overkill for most regular users) but still want the RoG feature set and dual GPU gaming, the Gene Z makes for a great choice.

Coming to the MSI Z68MA-ED55 (B3) board, you get a well laid out board with the Military Class II branding on the sturdy heatsinks. Beside the OC Genie button you have a little buzzer speaker and probe points to check voltages manually using the con-



ASUS Maximus IV Gene-Z